

Word family: **random / randomly / randomness / randomize / randomise / randomized / randomised**

Base word: random

Related forms: randomly, randomness, randomize / randomise, randomized / randomised

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / adverb-related forms (相關副詞) / noun-related form (相關名詞) / verb-related forms (相關動詞)

Your sentence:

> “That may sound a bit **random**, but when he speaks, everything comes alive.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **random** means **seemingly unrelated, unexpected, or without an obvious connection to the main topic**.

The speaker is saying that talking for fifteen minutes about old tram routes may sound a little unusual or disconnected at first, even though Mr. Wong can make it interesting.

繁體中文： ** **看起來與當前話題沒有明顯關連、突然出現或令人覺得有點莫名其妙的**

中文翻譯：

> “That may sound a bit **random**...”

「這聽起來也許有點**突然 / 有點莫名其妙 / 不太相關**.....」

Here:

random = 看似沒有明顯關連、出現得有點突然或令人摸不着頭腦的

1. **random = chosen/happening by chance (隨機的) — 隨機的 ; 任意抽取的**

This is the basic technical and general meaning.

Meaning: Chosen, happening, or arranged by chance rather than according to a deliberate pattern or plan.

Practice 1

> “The computer selected ten names at **random**.”

「電腦**隨機**選出了十個名字。」

Practice 2

> “Participants were assigned to groups in a **random** order.”

「參加者以**隨機次序**被分配到不同組別。」

random = 不是按照預定規律、偏好或計劃，而是由機會或隨機程序決定的

Common:

- * random number
- * random sample
- * random selection
- * random order
- * random choice

These all belong to the same chance-based sense.

2. **random** = without clear pattern/order (排列 / 分布) — 無規律的；雜亂的

Here, **random** describes something that appears not to follow an obvious pattern, order, or structure.

Practice 3

> “The dots appear in a **random** pattern.”

「這些點看起來呈現**沒有明顯規律的分布**。」

Practice 4

> “The files were placed in a seemingly **random** order.”

「這些檔案似乎以**毫無規律的次序**排列。」

random = 缺乏可辨認的固定規律、結構或排列次序的

For core counting, I would treat this as closely related to Meaning 1:

> **chance-based selection** → no predictable pattern

but it is useful enough to show separately because the learner concept shifts from **how something was chosen** to **how something appears to be organized**.

3. **random** = unrelated/unexpected/out of context (話題 / 說話 / 行為) — 突然的 ; 無關的 ; 莫名其妙的

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Unexpected or seemingly unrelated to what was happening or being discussed.

Practice 5 — Original

> “That may sound a bit **random**, but when he speaks, everything comes alive.”

「這聽起來也許有點**突然 / 莫名其妙 / 不太相關**，但他一說起來，一切都變得生動。」

Practice 6

> “That was a **random** question.”

「那是一個很**突然、跟當前話題沒甚麼關係的問題**。」

Practice 7

> “He made a completely **random** comment about trains.”

「他突然說了一句完全**沒頭沒尾 / 不太相關的火車話題**。」

random = 在對話或情境中看起來突然出現，而且與前後內容沒有明顯連繫

This is genuinely different from mathematical/statistical randomness, so it deserves a separate meaning.

4. **random** = odd/peculiar/strange in an informal way (人 / 事情) — 莫名其妙的 ; 古怪的

In informal English, **random** can also mean strange, unusual, or hard to explain.

Practice 8

> “That was such a **random** thing to do.”

「那真是一件很**莫名其妙 / 古怪**的事。」

Practice 9

> “I had a **random** dream about my old school.”

「我做了一個很**莫名其妙 / 奇怪**的夢，夢到以前的學校。」

random = 令人覺得古怪、出乎意料或難以解釋的；非正式

This overlaps strongly with Meaning 3.

For database counting, I would usually **merge 3 and 4** under the broader conversational sense:

> **unexpected / seemingly unrelated / oddly out of context**

5. **random person/stranger/item** (隨便某個) — 隨便的；任意一個

In everyday English, **random** can mean an arbitrary, unspecified member of a group.

Practice 10

> “A **random** person came up and asked me for directions.”

「一個**完全不認識、隨便出現的人**走過來問路。」

Practice 11

> “Pick a **random** book from the shelf.”

「從書架上**隨便挑一本書**。」

random + person/thing = 沒有特別指定或挑選理由，任意的一個人或事物

This is closely connected to the basic chance/arbitrary sense, but it is common enough in everyday speech to show explicitly.

Related form: **randomly**

Randomly means by chance, without a deliberate pattern, or unexpectedly depending on context.

Practice 12

> “The questions were **randomly** selected.”

「這些問題是**隨機抽選**的。」

Practice 13

> “He **randomly** started talking about his childhood.”

「他**突然 / 毫無預兆地**開始談起自己的童年。」

****randomly = 以隨機方式；或在口語中指突然、沒有明顯原因地****

This inherits both the technical and conversational senses of ****random****.

Related form: ****randomness****

****Randomness**** means the quality or condition of being random.

Practice 14

> “The experiment depends on true ****randomness****.”

「這項實驗依賴真正的****隨機性****。」

Practice 15

> “The apparent ****randomness**** of the pattern made it difficult to predict.”

「這個模式表面上的****無規律性 / 隨機性****令它很難預測。」

****randomness = 缺乏可預測規律，或由機會而非固定模式決定的性質****

Related form: ****randomize / randomise****

This verb means to arrange or select things randomly.

Practice 16

> “The software ****randomizes**** the order of the questions.”

「軟件會把問題次序****隨機排列****。」

Practice 17

> “Participants were **randomised** into two groups.”

「參加者被**隨機分配**到兩組。」

randomize/randomise = 令某個次序、分配或選擇由隨機程序決定

British English often uses **randomise**; American English uses **randomize**.

Important distinction: **random** vs **arbitrary**

These overlap, but not perfectly.

random

usually implies chance or lack of predictable pattern.

arbitrary

usually means based on no clear principle, reason, or fair rule.

> “A random number”

= 隨機數字

> “An arbitrary decision”

= 缺乏明確原則或合理依據的決定

Something can be arbitrary without being statistically random.

Important distinction: **random** vs **accidental**

random

= determined by chance or lacking an obvious pattern

accidental

= happening unintentionally

> “The names were chosen randomly.”

= 名字是隨機選的。

> “I deleted the file accidentally.”

= 我是不小心刪掉檔案的。

So:

****random ≠ accidental****

Important distinction: ****random vs strange****

****random****

in conversational English often means:

> unexpected / unrelated / out of context

****strange****

means:

> unusual, odd, or unfamiliar

Example:

> “That was a random question.”

= 那問題很突然、跟話題沒關係。

> “That was a strange question.”

= 那問題本身很奇怪。

There is overlap, but the focus differs.

Important distinction: ****random vs spontaneous****

****random****

often suggests lack of connection, plan, or pattern.

spontaneous

means naturally occurring without prior planning, often with a positive or neutral tone.

> “We took a spontaneous trip.”

= 我們臨時起意去旅行。

> “He made a random comment.”

= 他突然講了一句沒甚麼關連的話。

Not the same nuance.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **random**

* **randomly**

* **randomness**

* **randomize / randomise**

* **randomized / randomised**

Useful common expressions include:

* random number

* random sample

* random selection

* random order

* at random

* random person

* random question/comment

The Golden Manual says related forms and domain-specific uses should be included when useful, while overlapping uses should still be merged where one broader semantic concept explains them.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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random — chance-based selection/event	不是按照預定規律、偏好或計劃，而是由機會或隨機程序決定的	
random — no clear pattern/order	缺乏可辨認的固定規律、結構或排列次序的	
random — unrelated/unexpected in conversation	在當前話題或情境中突然出現、與前後內容沒有明顯關連的	
random — odd/peculiar, informal	令人覺得古怪、出乎意料或難以解釋的；與「突然 / 不相關」義高度相關	
random + person/thing	沒有特別指定或挑選理由，任意的一個人或事物	
randomly	以隨機方式；亦可在口語中表示突然、沒有明顯原因地	
randomness	缺乏可預測規律或由機會決定的性質；隨機性	
randomize/randomise	令次序、分配或選擇由隨機程序決定	

For your original sentence

> “That may sound a bit **random**, but when he speaks, everything comes alive.”

The exact meaning is:

random = 看起來突然、跟當前話題沒有明顯關連，或令人覺得有點莫名其妙的

So:

> **that may sound a bit random**

= **那聽起來可能有點突然 / 有點莫名其妙 / 不太相關**

For your database, I would count **3 genuinely useful core meanings** for **random**:

1. **chosen/happening by chance**
2. **lacking a clear pattern or order**
3. **informal — unexpected, unrelated, or oddly out of context**

I would merge **random person/item** into #1 and merge **odd/peculiar** conversational uses into #3 rather than create extra artificial meanings.